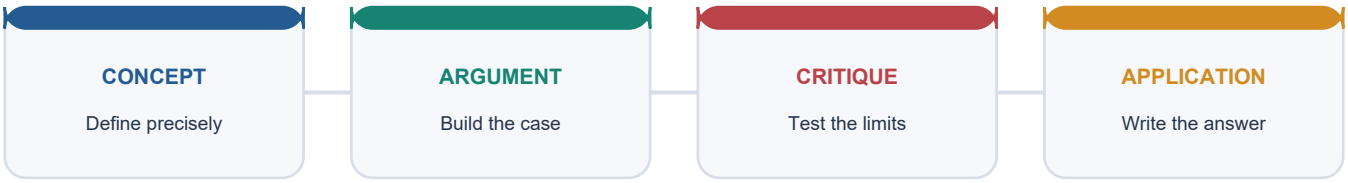
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Foundation of the Delhi Sultanate: The Slave (Mamluk) Dynasty - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Foundation of the Delhi Sultanate: The Slave (Mamluk) Dynasty - Solved Practice Workbook 4

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION 4

Workbook MCQ 01 4

Workbook MCQ 02 4

Workbook MCQ 03 5

Workbook MCQ 04 5

Workbook MCQ 05 5

Workbook MCQ 06 6

Workbook MCQ 07 6

Workbook MCQ 08 7

Workbook MCQ 09 7

Workbook MCQ 10 7

Workbook MCQ 11 8

Workbook MCQ 12 8

Workbook MCQ 13 9

Workbook MCQ 14 9

Workbook MCQ 15 9

Workbook MCQ 16 10

Workbook MCQ 17 10

Workbook MCQ 18 11

Workbook MCQ 19 11

Workbook MCQ 20 12

Workbook MCQ 21 12

Workbook MCQ 22 12

Workbook MCQ 23 13

Workbook MCQ 24 13

Workbook MCQ 25 14

Workbook MCQ 26 14

Workbook MCQ 27 14

Workbook MCQ 28 . . . 15
Workbook MCQ 29 . . . 15
Workbook MCQ 30 . . . 16
Workbook MCQ 31 . . . 16
Workbook MCQ 32 . . . 17
Remediation map - predictable errors and their correcting Workbook MCQs . . . 17
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE . . . 17
Adjacent PYQ 01 - 2019 Prelims GS-I Q12: revenue administration . . . 17
Adjacent PYQ 02 - 2022 Prelims GS-I Q57: Mongol invasions . . . 18
Adjacent PYQ 03 - 2020 GS-I Mains: Persian literary sources . . . 19
Mains 10M-2 - Iltutmish as consolidator . . . 20
Mains 10M-3 - Raziya's fall . . . 20
Mains 15M-1 - Crown and Chihalgani . . . 21
Mains 15M-3 - Early Sultanate architecture . . . 22
Mains 20M-1 - Nature of the early Sultanate . . . 22
Mains 20M-3 - Sources and historiography of the Mamluk century . . . 23

Foundation of the Delhi Sultanate: The Slave (Mamluk) Dynasty - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Workbook MCQ 01

Question: How did Raziya initially strengthen her accession?

- A. She combined Iltutmish's nomination with urban support in Delhi and division of the opposing elite.
- B. She inherited an uncontested male primogeniture rule.
- C. She received a papal decree.
- D. She conquered Ghazni before entering Delhi.

Answer: A - She combined Iltutmish's nomination with urban support in Delhi and division of the opposing elite.

- A. **Correct.** Her accession combined Iltutmish's own nomination with active Delhi mobilisation and elite division, so ability plus faction management put her on the throne, not birth order alone.
- B. **Incorrect.** There was no uncontested male primogeniture rule in this decade; Ruknuddin, Bahram and Masud were all removed by faction, not by an orderly succession law.
- C. **Incorrect.** No papal decree existed in the Delhi Sultanate; this option imports an unrelated medieval-Christian institution.
- D. **Incorrect.** Raziya did not conquer Ghazni; that theatre belonged to Iltutmish's earlier campaigns against Yildiz, a different ruler and a different decade.

Trap: treating Raziya's accession as either pure hereditary right or pure popular acclaim, instead of nomination plus mobilisation plus elite division.

Workbook MCQ 02

Question: Why was Yaqut's office politically sensitive?

- A. He commanded the Portuguese navy.
- B. As amir-i-akhur he controlled royal stables and proximity to the sovereign, challenging Turkish monopoly over strategic access.
- C. He collected all Bengal land revenue.
- D. He was caliph of Baghdad.

Answer: B - As amir-i-akhur he controlled royal stables and proximity to the sovereign, challenging Turkish monopoly over strategic access.

- A. **Incorrect.** Raziya's Delhi Sultanate had no Portuguese navy; the Portuguese arrive in Indian waters only from the late fifteenth century.
- B. **Correct.** The amir-i-akhur controlled the royal stables and, through them, physical proximity and access to the sovereign - a genuinely strategic post, which is why its holder's identity mattered politically.
- C. **Incorrect.** Bengal land revenue was governed by its own governors and later by Iltutmish's son, not by the amir-i-akhur, an entirely different court office.
- D. **Incorrect.** Yaqut was never caliph of Baghdad; conflating a royal-stable office with the Abbasid caliphate erases a real institutional distinction the question is testing.

Trap: reducing Yaqut's promotion to personal favour and missing that the office itself, not merely the man, threatened Turkish elite access.

Workbook MCQ 03

Question: Which claim about Raziya and Yaqut lacks contemporary support?

- A. That Turkish nobles resented his elevation.
- B. That he held the royal-stable office.
- C. That a romantic intimacy was the decisive cause of her fall.
- D. That he was killed during the rebellion.

Answer: C - That a romantic intimacy was the decisive cause of her fall.

- A. **Incorrect.** Noble resentment at Yaqut's elevation is exactly what Minhaj-based accounts do support, so this option is a true, well-evidenced claim, not the one lacking support.
- B. **Incorrect.** Yaqut's amir-i-akhur post is directly attested and central to the analysis, so this is also a supported claim.
- C. **Correct.** No contemporary source supports a decisive romantic intimacy between Raziya and Yaqut; Minhaj records resentment over office and rebellion, not an affair, so this causal claim is a later, unsupported addition.
- D. **Incorrect.** Yaqut's death during the rebellion against Raziya is part of the same near-contemporary narrative and is not in dispute.

Trap: the romance narrative is memorable and often repeated, which is precisely why an exam question isolates it as the one unsupported claim among otherwise solid facts.

Workbook MCQ 04

Question: Which factor best completes a balanced explanation of Raziya's fall?

- A. Yaqut alone controlled all policy.
- B. Gender alone explains every event.
- C. Delhi's population unanimously opposed her from the start.
- D. Gendered legitimacy interacted with noble faction, provincial force, strategic office and coalition failure.

Answer: D - Gendered legitimacy interacted with noble faction, provincial force, strategic office and coalition failure.

- A. **Incorrect.** Yaqut held one sensitive office, not total control of all policy; his death does not by itself explain the wider noble rebellion.
- B. **Incorrect.** Gender alone cannot explain why specific governors (Lahore, Tabarhinda) rebelled over specific offices and alliances - it explains vulnerability, not the whole mechanism.
- C. **Incorrect.** Delhi's population initially supported her accession at the congregational mosque; opposition grew later through elite and provincial action, not from unanimous early hostility.
- D. **Correct.** A complete explanation must combine gendered legitimacy, noble faction, provincial military force and coalition failure together, since each factor alone is insufficient to explain her deposition.

Trap: picking one true-sounding partial factor (gender, or one noble, or one city) instead of the required multi-causal synthesis.

Workbook MCQ 05

Question: What did the repeated deposition of rulers after Raziya show?

- A. Hereditary legitimacy remained useful, but effective monarchy depended on control of nobles, offices and troops.
- B. The caliph directly selected every sultan.
- C. All provinces became independent permanently.
- D. Delhi had no political institutions.

Answer: A - Hereditary legitimacy remained useful, but effective monarchy depended on control of nobles, offices and troops.

- A. **Correct.** The repeated depositions after Raziya show that hereditary claim alone could not secure the throne - actual control of nobles, offices and troops determined who stayed in power.
- B. **Incorrect.** The Abbasid caliph never personally selected Delhi's sultans; investiture (as with Iltutmish in 1229) was retrospective recognition, not appointment.
- C. **Incorrect.** Provinces such as Bengal became intermittently autonomous, not permanently independent; Delhi repeatedly reasserted suzerainty across this period.
- D. **Incorrect.** Delhi retained functioning institutions (iqta, army, chancery) throughout the crisis; the instability was political, not institutional collapse.

Trap: assuming repeated depositions mean the state itself had no institutions, rather than that hereditary title and operational power had become separated.

Workbook MCQ 06

Question: Which statement about Nasiruddin Mahmud is most defensible?

- A. He never issued or approved a royal act.
- B. Pious withdrawal is a strong literary image, but Balban's dominance was real, contested and not uninterrupted.
- C. He personally created Alauddin's market system.
- D. He ruled only one year.

Answer: B - Pious withdrawal is a strong literary image, but Balban's dominance was real, contested and not uninterrupted.

- A. **Incorrect.** Royal acts and administrative business continued under Nasiruddin Mahmud despite the pious-withdrawal image; a reigning sultan issuing zero acts for two decades is not evidenced.
- B. **Correct.** Balban was removed from his dominant position in 1253 and later returned by 1255, which proves his control over Nasiruddin Mahmud's court was real but contested, not a fixed, uninterrupted fact.
- C. **Incorrect.** Alauddin Khalji's market reforms belong to a different ruler and a later reign (Topic 04), decades after Nasiruddin Mahmud.
- D. **Incorrect.** Nasiruddin Mahmud reigned from 1246 to 1266, roughly two decades, not a single year.

Trap: taking the moralising 'pious, withdrawn sultan' image literally instead of reading it as a literary device that still allows for real, contested politics underneath.

Workbook MCQ 07

Question: Why is Minhaj's hostility to Raihan source-critically important?

- A. Minhaj was Raihan's son.
- B. Raihan wrote the Tabaqat.
- C. Minhaj lost office under Raihan, so institutional self-interest may shape blame.
- D. Minhaj lived two centuries before Raihan.

Answer: C - Minhaj lost office under Raihan, so institutional self-interest may shape blame.

- A. **Incorrect.** Minhaj was not related to Raihan; no father-son or family relationship is recorded between them.
- B. **Incorrect.** Minhaj, not Raihan, is the author of the *Tabaqat-i Nasiri*; this option reverses authorship.
- C. **Correct.** Minhaj lost his own office when Imaduddin Raihan rose to prominence, so his hostile account of Raihan carries a personal, institutional stake that a careful reader must weigh before accepting it as neutral.
- D. **Incorrect.** Minhaj and Raihan were contemporaries in the mid-thirteenth century, not separated by two centuries.

Trap: treating a chronicler's hostile portrayal of a rival as simple, disinterested reporting rather than checking the author's own institutional position first.

Workbook MCQ 08

Question: What was Balban's position before 1266?

- A. Portuguese governor of Goa.
- B. Caliph at Baghdad.
- C. Independent ruler of Bengal.
- D. A powerful naib and kingmaker whose supremacy was periodically challenged by other nobles.

Answer: D - A powerful naib and kingmaker whose supremacy was periodically challenged by other nobles.

- A. **Incorrect.** Balban held no Portuguese office; European colonial administration in Goa begins centuries later.
- B. **Incorrect.** The historical Abbasid caliph resided at Baghdad; Balban was never caliph, only a Delhi-based deputy and later sultan.
- C. **Incorrect.** Balban did not rule Bengal independently before 1266; Bengal's governors (including the later rebel Tughril) operated under separate, shifting arrangements.
- D. **Correct.** Before his formal accession in 1266, Balban was already the dominant naib (deputy) and kingmaker under Nasiruddin Mahmud, with his supremacy periodically challenged by rival nobles such as during the Raihan episode.

Trap: dating Balban's political importance only from his 1266 coronation and missing the two preceding decades as dominant naib.

Workbook MCQ 09

Question: What political function did Balban's court splendour serve?

- A. It transformed hierarchy and royal distance into visible awe over noble peers and visitors.
- B. It proved all Barani stories literal.
- C. It replaced the army entirely.
- D. It guaranteed hereditary succession.

Answer: A - It transformed hierarchy and royal distance into visible awe over noble peers and visitors.

- A. **Correct.** Balban's court splendour converted physical distance, ceremony and restricted access into visible awe, turning ritual into a political tool that placed the sultan above noble peers.
- B. **Incorrect.** Barani's dramatic account is a later, normative narrative and cannot be treated as a literal, verified transcript of every court event.
- C. **Incorrect.** Court ceremony supplemented, rather than replaced, Balban's army, barids and frontier defences - it was one instrument among several.
- D. **Incorrect.** Court splendour was about hierarchy and awe, not a succession guarantee; Balban's own succession plan later collapsed despite decades of ceremonial authority.

Trap: dismissing court ritual as empty decoration instead of recognising it as a deliberate technology of rule.

Workbook MCQ 10

Question: How should zil-i-allah be interpreted?

- A. As abolition of Islam.
- B. As a Persianate-Islamic claim that exalted the sultan's delegated sacred prestige above nobles, not literal godhood.
- C. As a revenue tax.
- D. As election by a modern parliament.

Answer: B - As a Persianate-Islamic claim that exalted the sultan's delegated sacred prestige above nobles, not literal godhood.

- A. **Incorrect.** The title does not abolish or replace Islam; it operates within an Islamic political vocabulary of delegated authority.

- B. **Correct.** *Zil-i-allah* ('shadow of God') is a Persianate-Islamic political idiom that elevated the sultan's delegated prestige above the nobility; it is a claim about rank and legitimacy, not literal divinity.
- C. **Incorrect.** It is a legitimising title, not a category of taxation; conflating the two erases the term's actual political function.
- D. **Incorrect.** No modern parliamentary election existed in the thirteenth-century Sultanate; the phrase describes monarchical, not representative, legitimacy.

Trap: reading a medieval religio-political title literally as a theological claim to godhood rather than as a rank-elevating idiom.

Workbook MCQ 11

Question: Why were sijda and paibos controversial?

- A. They were silver coins.
- B. They were names of Mongol forts.
- C. They dramatised royal subordination but could conflict with theologians' view that prostration belonged to God.
- D. They were Rajput land taxes.

Answer: C - They dramatised royal subordination but could conflict with theologians' view that prostration belonged to God.

- A. **Incorrect.** These terms name court rituals, not coins; no numismatic unit called sijda or paibos existed.
- B. **Incorrect.** Sijda and paibos are Persian-Arabic ritual terms, not the names of any Mongol fortification.
- C. **Correct.** *Sijda* (prostration) and *paibos* (foot-kissing) visibly dramatised a noble's subordination to the sultan, but some theologians objected because such prostration was traditionally reserved for God alone - creating genuine religious controversy.
- D. **Incorrect.** They describe bodily court gestures, not Rajput fiscal categories; the two belong to entirely different institutional domains.

Trap: seeing sijda/paibos only as effective political theatre and missing that the same rituals provoked a genuine theological objection.

Workbook MCQ 12

Question: What is wrong with quoting "blood and iron" as Balban's own slogan?

- A. It referred only to architecture.
- B. It was written on every Balban coin.
- C. It described Raziya's clothing.
- D. It is a later shorthand and must be tied to specific coercive policies rather than presented as a verified quotation.

Answer: D - It is a later shorthand and must be tied to specific coercive policies rather than presented as a verified quotation.

- A. **Incorrect.** The phrase is used for Balban's law-and-order and frontier coercion generally, not narrowly for architecture.
- B. **Incorrect.** No coin evidence carries this phrase; it is a modern historiographical label, not a numismatic legend.
- C. **Incorrect.** The phrase has nothing to do with Raziya or clothing; it describes coercive statecraft under Balban, a different ruler and a different topic.
- D. **Correct.** "Blood and iron" is a later historians' shorthand for Balban's coercive practices; it should be tied to specific named measures (forest clearance, punitive campaigns) rather than quoted as if Balban himself said it.

Trap: treating a vivid historian's shorthand as an authentic primary-source quotation that can be cited as Balban's own words.

Workbook MCQ 13

Question: What was the main purpose of Balban's barids?

- A. Independent intelligence on officials, provincial events and oppression.
- B. Translation of Sanskrit texts.
- C. Management of royal stables.
- D. Collection of sea customs in Gujarat.

Answer: A - Independent intelligence on officials, provincial events and oppression.

- A. **Correct.** Balban's *barids* existed mainly to give the centre independent intelligence on officials, provincial conditions and oppression, reducing his dependence on the self-interested reports of governors themselves.
- B. **Incorrect.** Barids were an intelligence/reporting institution, not a translation bureau; Sanskrit-text translation is not their attested function.
- C. **Incorrect.** Royal stables fell under the amir-i-akhur's charge (as with Yaqut under Raziya), a different office from the barid network.
- D. **Incorrect.** Sea-customs collection in Gujarat is a fiscal-administrative function unrelated to, and not evidenced for, the barid intelligence system.

Trap: confusing the barid (intelligence) with other named offices (amir-i-akhur, revenue collectors) that appear elsewhere in the same topic.

Workbook MCQ 14

Question: Why are Barani's justice stories useful but limited?

- A. They prove abolition of slavery.
- B. They illustrate an ideal and possible exemplary enforcement, not a complete record of equal justice.
- C. They are modern court judgements.
- D. They contain no named officials.

Answer: B - They illustrate an ideal and possible exemplary enforcement, not a complete record of equal justice.

- A. **Incorrect.** Slavery as an institution continued through this period; these anecdotes are about elite punishment, not the abolition of slavery.
- B. **Correct.** Barani's stories about punishing officials like Bakbak and Haibat Khan illustrate the ideal of impartial royal justice and show it was sometimes enforced, but they were selected exemplary tales, not a comprehensive record of equal justice for all subjects.
- C. **Incorrect.** These are thirteenth-century chronicle narratives by Barani, not modern court judgments with formal legal records.
- D. **Incorrect.** The stories do name specific officials (Malik Bakbak of Badaun, Haibat Khan of Awadh), which is precisely why they function as evidence at all.

Trap: treating a small set of dramatic, selected justice anecdotes as proof of a complete and equal judicial system.

Workbook MCQ 15

Question: What did Balban's inquiry into old soldiers' village assignments attempt?

- A. To abolish the diwan-i-arz.
- B. To transfer every soldier to Bengal.
- C. To reconnect revenue assignment with actual military service and reduce unearned retention.
- D. To create hereditary zamindari.

Answer: C - To reconnect revenue assignment with actual military service and reduce unearned retention.

- A. **Incorrect.** The reform targeted specific unfit assignment-holders; it was not an attempt to abolish the *diwan-i-arz*, the department that oversaw army administration itself.
- B. **Incorrect.** There is no record of a mass transfer of soldiers to Bengal as part of this specific administrative reform.
- C. **Correct.** Balban's inquiry into aging soldiers who still held village revenue assignments aimed to reconnect those assignments with actual military service, reducing revenue retained without corresponding duty.
- D. **Incorrect.** The measure pushed against unearned, entrenched holdings; it did not aim to create hereditary zamindari-style landholding, which would contradict its stated purpose.

Trap: confusing an accountability reform aimed at unearned military assignments with an unrelated administrative abolition or land-grant scheme.

Workbook MCQ 16

Question: Which is the most balanced view of Balban's Mewat policy?

- A. It was a naval campaign.
- B. It permanently ended all regional resistance without coercion.
- C. It was a peaceful irrigation project only.
- D. It restored capital-route security through forest clearance, posts and settlement, but involved severe violence and displacement.

Answer: D - It restored capital-route security through forest clearance, posts and settlement, but involved severe violence and displacement.

- A. **Incorrect.** Mewat lies inland near Delhi; this was a land-based law-and-order campaign, not a naval operation.
- B. **Incorrect.** Resistance around Delhi and the doab recurred across reigns; the campaign reduced but did not permanently end all regional resistance.
- C. **Incorrect.** Chronicle accounts describe forest clearance and punitive military action, not a peaceful irrigation project.
- D. **Correct.** Balban's Mewat policy combined forest clearance, military posts and Afghan settlement to restore security on routes near the capital, but this security was achieved through severe violence and displacement, not peaceful means.

Trap: praising the resulting route security without acknowledging the coercive, violent means (forest clearance, displacement) that produced it.

Workbook MCQ 17

Question: Why did Balban avoid distant conquest?

- A. Mongol pressure required a royal reserve near Delhi and sustained frontier vigilance.
- B. He had no army.
- C. The caliph prohibited all campaigns.
- D. He was unaware of Malwa and Gujarat.

Answer: A - Mongol pressure required a royal reserve near Delhi and sustained frontier vigilance.

- A. **Correct.** Because Mongol pressure west of Lahore was a live and recurring danger, Balban kept a royal reserve near Delhi and maintained sustained frontier vigilance rather than committing forces to distant campaigns.
- B. **Incorrect.** Balban commanded a functioning army throughout his reign, including campaigns against Tughril in Bengal; the claim that he had no army is factually wrong.
- C. **Incorrect.** No caliph held enforceable authority over Delhi's military decisions; caliphal investiture (1229, under Iltutmish) was symbolic, not a command relationship.
- D. **Incorrect.** Balban was well aware of Malwa and Gujarat as regions; his restraint was a strategic choice driven by the Mongol threat, not ignorance.

Trap: mistaking Balban's strategic caution for weakness or ignorance rather than a deliberate defensive prioritisation.

Workbook MCQ 18

Question: What was the practical frontier under much of Balban's period?

- A. The Oxus River under complete Delhi rule.
- B. A defensive zone focused around the Beas and forts such as Tabarhinda, Sunam and Samana, with Multan under pressure.
- C. The Narmada as a Mongol frontier.
- D. The Bay of Bengal coast.

Answer: B - A defensive zone focused around the Beas and forts such as Tabarhinda, Sunam and Samana, with Multan under pressure.

- A. **Incorrect.** Delhi never held complete, secure rule up to the Oxus; this vastly overstates the Sultanate's actual northwestern reach.
- B. **Correct.** For much of Balban's reign the practical frontier was a defensive zone anchored on the Beas and forts like Tabarhinda, Sunam and Samana, with Multan itself remaining under Mongol pressure.
- C. **Incorrect.** The Narmada lies far to the south in central India and was never a Mongol frontier; the real Mongol pressure was in the northwest.
- D. **Incorrect.** The Bay of Bengal coast is unconnected to the Mongol frontier, which was a northwestern, not eastern-coastal, problem.

Trap: assuming Sultanate frontiers were uniformly secure or uniformly exposed, rather than naming the actual contested defensive line.

Workbook MCQ 19

Question: What is the correct assessment of Hulegu-Balban diplomacy?

- A. It made Balban Hulegu's governor.
- B. It ended every Mongol incursion forever.
- C. It helped manage a frontier status quo while wider Mongol priorities and local raids continued.
- D. It transferred Baghdad to Delhi.

Answer: C - It helped manage a frontier status quo while wider Mongol priorities and local raids continued.

- A. **Incorrect.** Balban remained sultan of Delhi in his own right; the exchange did not subordinate him as Hulegu's governor.
- B. **Incorrect.** Mongol incursions continued in various forms after this diplomacy (e.g., pressure that later killed Prince Muhammad in 1285); the threat did not end forever.
- C. **Correct.** The Balban-Hulegu diplomatic exchange helped manage a working frontier status quo, but it coexisted with continuing wider Mongol priorities elsewhere and continuing local raids - it did not end the threat outright.
- D. **Incorrect.** No transfer of Baghdad's seat to Delhi occurred; this conflates unrelated Ilkhanate and Delhi Sultanate political geography.

Trap: reading diplomatic contact as either total capitulation or total resolution, instead of a managed, partial accommodation.

Workbook MCQ 20

Question: Why was Prince Muhammad's death in 1285 especially important?

- A. It founded the Khalji dynasty immediately.
- B. It created the Qutb Minar.
- C. It ended Bengal's autonomy.
- D. It removed Balban's trained heir and exposed the succession weakness of his personal monarchy.

Answer: D - It removed Balban's trained heir and exposed the succession weakness of his personal monarchy.

- A. **Incorrect.** The Khalji dynasty was founded in 1290 by Jalaluddin Khalji, five years later and through a separate sequence of events, not immediately upon Prince Muhammad's death.
- B. **Incorrect.** The Qutb Minar was begun decades earlier under Aibak and Iltutmish; it has no connection to this 1285 event.
- C. **Incorrect.** Bengal's autonomy actually persisted and resurfaced after Balban's death under Bughra Khan; it was not ended by this event.
- D. **Correct.** Prince Muhammad was Balban's chosen, frontier-trained heir; his death fighting the Mongols in 1285 removed that succession plan and exposed how dependent Balban's personal monarchy was on one trained successor.

Trap: underrating a single succession-plan death as a minor frontier casualty rather than the structural trigger for the dynasty's later collapse.

Workbook MCQ 21

Question: What does Tughril's Bengal rebellion reveal?

- A. Remote governors could turn revenue, elephants, troops and distance into a rival sovereignty.
- B. Bengal was always directly audited.
- C. Balban never campaigned outside Delhi.
- D. The Mongols governed Lakhnauti.

Answer: A - Remote governors could turn revenue, elephants, troops and distance into a rival sovereignty.

- A. **Correct.** Tughril's rebellion shows that a remote governor could convert Bengal's revenue, war-elephants, troops and sheer distance from Delhi into a genuine rival claim to sovereignty.
- B. **Incorrect.** Bengal's history under the Sultanate is one of recurring rebellion and reassertion, not continuous, direct auditing from Delhi.
- C. **Incorrect.** Balban personally led the campaign against Tughril, contradicting any claim that he never campaigned outside Delhi.
- D. **Incorrect.** The Mongols did not govern Lakhnauti; it was ruled by Delhi-appointed or rebellious Bengali governors such as Tughril himself.

Trap: assuming Bengal's formal subordination to Delhi meant continuous, enforced administrative control rather than intermittent, force-dependent suzerainty.

Workbook MCQ 22

Question: Why does Balban's final Bengal victory not prove permanent integration?

- A. The victory occurred under Akbar.
- B. Bughra Khan later preferred an autonomous Bengal and Delhi's command again weakened.
- C. Tughril became sultan of Delhi.
- D. Bengal disappeared as a region.

Answer: B - Bughra Khan later preferred an autonomous Bengal and Delhi's command again weakened.

- A. **Incorrect.** This victory belongs to Balban's own reign in the 1280s, centuries before Akbar's rule.

- B. **Correct.** Balban's defeat of Tughril did not secure lasting integration, since his own son Bughra Khan later chose to rule an autonomous Bengal instead of contesting for or holding Delhi's throne.
- C. **Incorrect.** Tughril was defeated and killed by Balban; he never became sultan of Delhi.
- D. **Incorrect.** Bengal continued to exist as a political region under successive rulers; it did not disappear after this campaign.

Trap: treating a single successful punitive campaign as proof of permanent administrative integration rather than temporary reassertion of authority.

Workbook MCQ 23

Question: Which statement best defines iqta?

- A. A tax-free temple grant only.
- B. A modern district elected council.
- C. A transferable claim to collect state revenue for service and administration, subject in principle to audit and recall.
- D. Private hereditary ownership of land and peasants.

Answer: C - A transferable claim to collect state revenue for service and administration, subject in principle to audit and recall.

- A. **Incorrect.** Iqta was a general revenue-service assignment covering many purposes, not narrowly a tax-free temple endowment.
- B. **Incorrect.** No elected district council existed in the Delhi Sultanate; this imports a modern democratic institution anachronistically.
- C. **Correct.** Iqta was a transferable claim to collect state revenue in exchange for service and administration, kept in principle subject to central audit and recall - a fiscal-military tool of the state, not private property.
- D. **Incorrect.** Iqta explicitly was not private, hereditary ownership of land and peasants; that is exactly the misconception the term is meant to correct.

Trap: conflating iqta with permanent, hereditary land ownership (European-style feudalism) instead of a transferable, service-linked revenue claim.

Workbook MCQ 24

Question: How did local intermediaries affect Sultanate centralisation?

- A. They were abolished in 1206.
- B. They had no role outside trade.
- C. They existed only in Baghdad.
- D. They supplied knowledge, collection and coercive links, making central claims dependent on negotiated local power.

Answer: D - They supplied knowledge, collection and coercive links, making central claims dependent on negotiated local power.

- A. **Incorrect.** Local chiefs, headmen and revenue intermediaries continued to operate after 1206; they were not abolished at the Sultanate's founding.
- B. **Incorrect.** These intermediaries were essential to assessment, collection and order, not confined to trade alone.
- C. **Incorrect.** Such intermediaries existed across the Sultanate's own territories in India, not exclusively in distant Baghdad.
- D. **Correct.** Local intermediaries supplied the knowledge, revenue collection and coercive links the centre depended on, which meant Delhi's central claims to authority were only as strong as these negotiated local arrangements allowed.

Trap: picturing Sultanate centralisation as purely top-down command, ignoring how dependent the apex was on negotiated local intermediaries.

Workbook MCQ 25

Question: Which office handled state correspondence?

- A. Diwan-i-insha.
- B. Diwan-i-Kohi under Iltutmish.
- C. Amir-i-akhur.
- D. Mir Bakshi.

Answer: A - Diwan-i-insha.

- A. **Correct.** The *diwan-i-insha* was the chancery department responsible for drafting and handling state correspondence.
- B. **Incorrect.** "Diwan-i-Kohi" is not an attested Sultanate correspondence department; this option invents an unrelated label.
- C. **Incorrect.** The *amir-i-akhur* supervised the royal stables (as with Yaqut), an entirely different function from chancery correspondence.
- D. **Incorrect.** *Mir Bakshi* is a Mughal-era military-administrative office and did not exist under the early Delhi Sultanate.

Trap: substituting a later Mughal office (Mir Bakshi) or an invented department name for the Sultanate's actual chancery, the diwan-i-insha.

Workbook MCQ 26

Question: Which office is associated with military administration under the Sultanate?

- A. Sadr as cavalry commander.
- B. Diwan-i-arz under the ariz, while the sultan remained commander-in-chief.
- C. Kotwal as caliph.
- D. Mir Bakshi under Aibak.

Answer: B - Diwan-i-arz under the ariz, while the sultan remained commander-in-chief.

- A. **Incorrect.** The *sadr* handled religious/charitable grants and related functions, not cavalry command.
- B. **Correct.** Military administration operated through the *diwan-i-arz* under the *ariz* (muster and recruitment officer), while the sultan himself remained the ultimate commander-in-chief.
- C. **Incorrect.** The *kotwal* was an urban police/order officer, not the caliph, an entirely different and non-Sultanate office.
- D. **Incorrect.** *Mir Bakshi* is a later Mughal office; projecting it back onto Aibak's reign is a chronological error.

Trap: importing the later Mughal military office (Mir Bakshi) into the earlier Sultanate period instead of naming the diwan-i-arz/ariz.

Workbook MCQ 27

Question: What is the safest meaning of "Persianate"?

- A. A synonym for Shia state.
- B. A biological Persian race ruling without Indian participation.
- C. A transregional Persian-language court and administrative culture that could include people of varied origins.
- D. A style limited to poetry.

Answer: C - A transregional Persian-language court and administrative culture that could include people of varied origins.

- A. **Incorrect.** Persianate culture was not confined to, or synonymous with, any single sectarian identity such as Shia Islam.
- B. **Incorrect.** The term explicitly rejects a biological-racial reading; Indian, Turkish, Tajik and other groups all participated in Persianate court culture.

- C. **Correct.** "Persianate" safely means a transregional Persian-language court and administrative culture that people of varied ethnic and religious origins could participate in - a cultural-linguistic sphere, not an ethnic or sectarian category.
- D. **Incorrect.** Persianate culture extended well beyond poetry into administration, chancery practice and court ceremony.

Trap: treating a language-and-culture label as if it named a fixed ethnicity or religious sect, erasing the diverse participants it actually included.

Workbook MCQ 28

Question: Which monument began under Aibak before his independent reign?

- A. Balban's tomb.
- B. Alai Darwaza.
- C. Tughlaqabad.
- D. Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque, begun in 1198 within the Ghurid conquest phase.

Answer: D - Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque, begun in 1198 within the Ghurid conquest phase.

- A. **Incorrect.** Balban's tomb belongs to the late thirteenth century, decades after the Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque's 1198 foundation.
- B. **Incorrect.** The Alai Darwaza is an early-fourteenth-century Khalji-era structure, well outside the Mamluk period this topic covers.
- C. **Incorrect.** Tughlaqabad is a fourteenth-century Tughlaq-dynasty fort, unrelated to Aibak's 1198 conquest-phase building.
- D. **Correct.** The Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque was begun in 1198, while Aibak was still a Ghurid commander acting under Muizz al-Din's authority - before his independent reign began in 1206.

Trap: assuming every monument associated with Aibak was built only after his independent 1206 accession, missing that construction began earlier, under delegated Ghurid authority.

Workbook MCQ 29

Question: What is the correct patronage sequence for Qutb Minar?

- A. Aibak laid the foundation and raised the first storey; Iltutmish added three; later rulers repaired or altered it.
- B. Raziya built all storeys in 1236.
- C. Alauddin completed it before Tarain.
- D. Balban built it after 1287.

Answer: A - Aibak laid the foundation and raised the first storey; Iltutmish added three; later rulers repaired or altered it.

- A. **Correct.** Aibak laid the foundation and raised the Qutb Minar's first storey; Iltutmish completed three more storeys; later rulers carried out subsequent repairs and alterations - a genuinely multi-ruler construction sequence.
- B. **Incorrect.** Raziya's brief 1236-40 reign left no attested role in the Qutb Minar's construction; she did not build all its storeys.
- C. **Incorrect.** Alauddin Khalji ruled decades after Tarain (1192) and could not have completed a monument "before" a battle that preceded his own reign.
- D. **Incorrect.** Balban ruled 1266-87, and the Minar's main storeys were already built by Iltutmish decades earlier, long before 1287.

Trap: attributing the entire monument to a single ruler instead of recognising its genuine multi-phase, multi-ruler construction history.

Workbook MCQ 30

Question: How should temple material at Quwwat-ul-Islam be treated?

- A. As proof that no temple material was used.
- B. As evidence of conquest-era demolition/reuse, expediency, public claims and local craft, without reducing the whole monument to one slogan.
- C. As evidence that Aibak invented stone carving.
- D. As proof of purely harmonious borrowing.

Answer: B - As evidence of conquest-era demolition/reuse, expediency, public claims and local craft, without reducing the whole monument to one slogan.

- A. **Incorrect.** ASI's own inscriptional evidence records reused Hindu and Jaina temple members; denying reuse contradicts the primary material evidence.
- B. **Correct.** The reused temple material at Quwwat-ul-Islam is best read as evidence of conquest-era demolition and reuse, practical expediency, public political claims, and local craft skill all at once - not reducible to one single slogan.
- C. **Incorrect.** Reused carved material shows earlier, pre-existing temple craftsmanship being incorporated, not Aibak inventing stone-carving from scratch.
- D. **Incorrect.** The same reuse also records conquest and appropriation, so calling it "purely harmonious" ignores the coercive dimension the material itself documents.

Trap: forcing the same physical evidence of reuse into either a purely destructive or purely harmonious single-word narrative.

Workbook MCQ 31

Question: Which statement corrects the state-character error?

- A. It had no central institutions.
- B. It was a modern unitary bureaucracy.
- C. The Sultanate was centralised at the apex but relied on provincial and local networks for implementation.
- D. Every village was governed directly from Delhi.

Answer: C - The Sultanate was centralised at the apex but relied on provincial and local networks for implementation.

- A. **Incorrect.** Central institutions such as the diwan-i-arz, diwan-i-insha and barid intelligence network genuinely existed; the Sultanate was not institution-free.
- B. **Incorrect.** Distance, revolt (Bengal, Punjab) and negotiated local power show the state was not a modern unitary bureaucracy with uniform direct control.
- C. **Correct.** The correct, corrected state-character claim is that the Sultanate was centralised at its apex (sultan, currency, army, iqta) while depending on provincial and local networks to actually implement that authority.
- D. **Incorrect.** Villages were governed through local chiefs, muqaddams and intermediaries, not through direct Delhi administration reaching every settlement.

Trap: resolving the centralisation debate by picking one extreme (no institutions, or perfect uniform bureaucracy) instead of the apex-versus-implementation distinction.

Workbook MCQ 32

Question: Which statement corrects the dynastic-decline error?

- A. The Khaljis abolished iqta and Persian administration immediately.
- B. The Delhi Sultanate ended permanently in 1290.
- C. Balban founded the Mughal Empire.
- D. The Mamluk line ended in 1290, but its Delhi-centred institutions continued and enabled Khalji expansion.

Answer: D - The Mamluk line ended in 1290, but its Delhi-centred institutions continued and enabled Khalji expansion.

- A. **Incorrect.** The Khaljis did not immediately abolish iqta or Persian administration; they continued and built upon these Mamluk-era institutions.
- B. **Incorrect.** The Delhi Sultanate as a state continued well after 1290, through the Khalji, Tughlaq and later dynasties; only the Mamluk ruling house ended.
- C. **Incorrect.** Balban ruled over a century before the Mughal Empire was founded (1526); no direct dynastic link connects the two.
- D. **Correct.** The corrected dynastic-decline claim is that the Mamluk ruling line ended in 1290, but the Delhi-centred institutions it built (iqta, army, chancery) survived and were inherited and expanded by the Khaljis.

Trap: confusing the end of one ruling house (the Mamluks, 1290) with the end of the Delhi-centred state itself, which continued under new rulers.

Remediation map - predictable errors and their correcting Workbook MCQs

Predictable error	Corrected by
Treating Raziya's fall as gender-only or romance-only	Workbook MCQ 03, 04, 20
Reading Chihalgani/Balban ritual as literal or purely decorative	Workbook MCQ 10, 11
Quoting "blood and iron" as a verified Balban statement	Workbook MCQ 12
Treating iqta as hereditary land ownership	Workbook MCQ 23
Assuming a single campaign (Bengal, Mongol frontier) proved permanent control	Workbook MCQ 19, 21, 22
Attributing a multi-phase monument to one ruler or reducing spolia to one slogan	Workbook MCQ 28, 29, 30, 31
Collapsing the centralised-vs-networked debate into one extreme	Workbook MCQ 31
Confusing the 1290 dynastic end with the end of the Sultanate state	Workbook MCQ 32

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Adjacent PYQ 01 - 2019 Prelims GS-I Q12: revenue administration

Verified question: Consider the following statements:

1. In the revenue administration of Delhi Sultanate, the in-charge of revenue collection was known as "Amil".
2. The Iqta system of Sultans of Delhi was an ancient indigenous institution.
3. The office of "Mir Bakshi" came into existence during the reign of Khalji Sultans of Delhi.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: A, 1 only. Confidence: high.

Solved explanation

- Statement 1 is correct: *amil* was a revenue-collection official.
- Statement 2 is incorrect: iqta had West and Central Asian antecedents. Under Delhi it became an adapted fiscal-military assignment; it was not an ancient indigenous institution.
- Statement 3 is incorrect: *Mir Bakshi* belongs to the Mughal administrative order. The Sultanate military department was associated with the *ariz* and *diwan-i-arz*.
- Topic significance: The question tests whether institutions are placed in the correct polity and whether iqta is mistaken for an indigenous hereditary land system.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates every statement independently, distinguishes institutional origin from Indian adaptation and avoids projecting a Mughal office backward.

Demand decoding: This is a three-statement elimination question, not a definition question - each statement names a distinct institution (*amil*, iqta, *Mir Bakshi*) and the correct response requires verifying each independently rather than treating the set as one claim about "Sultanate administration."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: State the *amil* fact first since it is uncontested; then attack statement 2 by naming the iqta's West/Central Asian antecedents (this is the trap statement, since "ancient indigenous" sounds plausible but is factually reversed); then eliminate statement 3 by placing *Mir Bakshi* correctly in the Mughal, not Sultanate, administrative order; conclude with option A.

How to improve this answer: Add the specific counter-fact that the Sultanate's own military department used the *ariz*/*diwan-i-arz* terminology, so a candidate who only remembers "Mir Bakshi is Mughal" without the Sultanate-era equivalent term loses precision marks in a written elimination note.

Adjacent PYQ 02 - 2022 Prelims GS-I Q57: Mongol invasions

Verified question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 1 and 2
- B. 2 only
- C. 1 and 3
- D. 3 only

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: B, 2 only. Confidence: high.

Solved explanation

- Statement 1 is incorrect: Mongol pressure reached the Indus in Iltutmish's reign in 1221 with Chinggis Khan's pursuit of Jalaluddin Mangbarani; Lahore was sacked in 1241, well before Jalaluddin Khalji.
- Statement 2 is correct: major Mongol assaults reached Delhi in Alauddin Khalji's reign, including the 1303 crisis associated with Siri.
- Statement 3 is incorrect in the wording used: Muhammad bin Tughlaq faced Mongol diplomacy and frontier issues, but the stated temporary loss is not the standard event.
- Topic significance: The Mamluk period established the strategic problem and the Beas-frontier response later inherited by the Khaljis.

Why this earns marks: It anchors each statement to ruler and date, separates first pressure from later siege and avoids letting a familiar Tughlaq name validate an unsupported statement.

Demand decoding: This question tests chronology attribution across three rulers (Jalal-ud-din Khalji, Ala-ud-din Khalji, Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq) - the trap is assuming "first Mongol invasion" means the first Khalji-era clash, when Mongol pressure actually began under Iltutmish decades earlier, which statement 1 conceals by omission rather than

by an explicit false date.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open by dating the true first pressure (1221 Mangbarani crisis, 1241 Lahore sack) to eliminate statement 1; confirm statement 2 using the 1303 Delhi/Siri crisis under Alauddin Khalji; treat statement 3 cautiously since "temporarily lost portions" is not the standard description of Muhammad bin Tughlaq's Mongol dealings; select option B.

How to improve this answer: Name the Mamluk-era origin of the "first pressure" explicitly (1221, then 1241) rather than only refuting statement 1 abstractly, since that is the exact link that ties this 2022 question back to Topic 03's own frontier sessions.

Adjacent PYQ 03 - 2020 GS-I Mains: Persian literary sources

Verified question: "Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age." Comment. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- **Direct thesis:** Persian works reflect the age because their genres record conquest, court hierarchy, political ethics, urban culture and administrative aspiration; yet they reflect an elite courtly age more fully than the whole population.
- **Early conquest and legitimacy:** Hasan Nizami's *Taj-ul-Ma'asir* celebrates Ghurid-Aibak success in ornate panegyric. Its language reveals the ideology of victory and new court patronage, although literary display and selective chronology limit factual extraction.
- **Dynastic and institutional world:** Minhaj-us-Siraj's *Tabaqat-i Nasiri* preserves the Ghurid-Mamluk sequence, Bakhtiyar's career, Iltutmish's consolidation and Raziya's politics. Minhaj's praise of Raziya's qualities followed by a gendered judgement exposes both the possibility of female sovereignty and clerical-patriarchal assumptions.
- **Kingship and aristocracy:** Barani's later *Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi* depicts the Chihalgani, Balban's court ritual, noble exclusivity, intelligence and justice. His *Fatawa-i Jahandari* reveals an aristocratic normative order, but his hostility to low-born advancement and chronological distance require corroboration.
- **Military-political advice:** Fakhr-i Mudabbir's writing illuminates ideals of army, hierarchy and Persianate statecraft. Prescriptive ideals cannot be equated with uniform practice.
- **Silences and checks:** These texts privilege male elites, capitals, war and office. Coins, inscriptions, Qutb architecture, local traditions and regional evidence are needed for currency, patronage, craft, non-elite life and implementation.
- **Conclusion:** Persian literary sources do reflect the spirit of medieval court and state formation, but only a source-critical, comparative reading converts that spirit into social history.

Why this earns marks: It comments rather than lists, uses four named authors and works, links evidence to political, gender and social meaning, and explicitly qualifies patronage and silence.

Demand decoding: "Comment" requires a direct evaluative position on whether Persian sources reflect "the spirit of the age," supported by named authors and texts, not a descriptive list of chronicles.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open with the qualified thesis (reflects the age, but an elite courtly one); take Hasan Nizami, Minhaj-us-Siraj, Barani and Fakhr-i Mudabbir as four evidence units in claim-evidence-limit form; close with the silences (coins, inscriptions, architecture, regional/non-elite life) that Persian literary sources alone cannot supply.

How to improve this answer: Name one specific silence the model leaves generic - for example, state explicitly that no Persian chronicle in this set reports the material terms of a specific iqta grant, so numismatic or epigraphic evidence must supply that gap rather than court narrative.

PYQ search conclusion

- No direct standalone GS Mains question devoted only to Aibak, Iltutmish, Raziya or Balban was located in the bounded repository 2018-2025 paper/routing set.
- No verified PYQ is routed directly to Topic 03. These three questions are retained only as adjacent applications with their true owners.

Mains 10M-2 - Iltutmish as consolidator

Question: Why is Iltutmish regarded as the principal consolidator of the Delhi Sultanate? (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Iltutmish converted Aibak's fragile Ghurid inheritance into an independent, defensible and Delhi-centred polity through sequenced military, fiscal and symbolic measures.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: He defeated Aram Shah and resistant Turkish officers, securing the capital core. This settled immediate succession, though noble faction survived.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: He eliminated Yildiz's senior claim and Qubacha's Multan-Uch-Sind state by 1228. Delhi gained strategic autonomy, but later Punjab control remained exposed.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: In 1221 he avoided alliance with Mangbarani against Chinggis Khan. Prudence preserved the weak state; it was not a military victory.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Repeated Bengal campaigns and fort recovery at Bayana, Gwalior and Ranthambhor widened suzerainty. Gujarat failure and Bengal rebellion show uneven reach.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Iqta discipline, tanka-jital currency, Delhi patronage and 1229 caliphal investiture strengthened institutions and legitimacy without being invented from nothing.
- Conclusion: He was "real founder" in consolidation, not creator of uniform rule.

Why this earns marks: It covers territorial, diplomatic, fiscal, monetary, capital and legitimacy dimensions with precise qualifications proportional to ten marks.

Demand decoding: "Why is X regarded as Y" demands a causal-justification structure - each paragraph must show a specific problem Aibak's brief reign left unresolved and how Iltutmish specifically solved it, not a general biography.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 150 words, use exactly three evidence clusters (rival elimination by 1228; Mongol-crisis prudence in 1221; iqta/currency/caliphal institution-building) rather than trying to list every campaign, and end with the "real founder, not creator of uniform rule" verdict in one sentence.

How to improve this answer: Add the specific caveat that Bengal and Gujarat resisted permanent incorporation even under Iltutmish, so the answer does not accidentally imply flawless, universal consolidation.

Mains 10M-3 - Raziya's fall

Question: Raziya's fall cannot be explained by gender alone. Explain. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Gender structured Raziya's vulnerability, but her fall resulted from the interaction of gendered legitimacy, noble corporate interests, strategic office and provincial military power.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Iltutmish nominated her over surviving sons and Minhaj praised her prudence, justice and warfare. Ability was recognised, but nomination did not bind the nobles.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: She appeared unveiled, held court and led armies. Visible sovereignty challenged gender expectations; it also expressed direct monarchy.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Yaqut's appointment as amir-i-akhur threatened Turkish monopoly over a strategic office close to the ruler. Contemporary evidence does not support a romance.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Lahore and Tabarhinda governors rebelled within a wider Delhi faction. Her coalition lacked the durable armed household needed to survive coordinated opposition.
- Conclusion: Gender gave opponents a language of exclusion, while office, faction and military resources turned prejudice into deposition.

Why this earns marks: It answers the "not alone" demand, uses Iltutmish, Minhaj, Yaqut and provincial rebellions as evidence, and rejects unsupported romance.

Demand decoding: "Cannot be explained by X alone. Explain" requires naming gender as one real factor while demonstrating at least two additional, independent causal factors with their own evidence - a purely gender-only or purely non-gender answer both fail this demand.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 150 words, sequence exactly three factors - recognised capacity/nomination, the Yaqut/office trigger, and provincial-military coalition failure - each with one named piece of evidence, then close by stating gender supplied the language of opposition while office and force supplied its means.

How to improve this answer: Explicitly reject the romance narrative in one sentence with the elephant-procession counter-detail, since examiners specifically credit answers that name and dismiss the popular misconception rather than merely omitting it.

Mains 15M-1 - Crown and Chihalgani

Question: Examine the monarchy-nobility struggle under the Mamluks with reference to the Chihalgani. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The Chihalgani symbolises the paradox of military-slave state formation: Iltutmish's household officers strengthened the monarchy, but their accumulated iqtas, commands and equality claims destabilised succession and enabled one of them, Balban, to destroy peer rule.
- Formation: Iltutmish promoted trained slave officers within a wider elite of free Turks and Tajik administrators. Household dependence supplied loyal service during consolidation. Yet office, marriage and provincial command created independent resources.
- Source caution: Barani later called them the "Corps of Forty." The advanced source identifies fewer than twenty-five and notes that they were not consistently united. The term denotes a prestige network, not a literal cabinet.
- Succession crisis: After 1236 governors and court officers enthroned or removed Ruknuddin, Raziya, Bahram and Masud. A naib-wazir-mustaufi combination briefly reduced the ruler, but factional conflict prevented stable oligarchy.
- Raziya: Her attempt at direct rule and Yaqut's elevation threatened Turkish strategic-office monopoly. Gender was instrumentalised within the larger crown-peer contest.
- Balban as naib: He rose from the same network, was removed in 1253, rebuilt alliances and returned. This proves that no corporate body possessed settled constitutional control.
- Balban as sultan: Court ritual, barids, punishment and elimination of rivals ended the claim that nobles were royal equals. However, narrow high-born ideology and personal coercion did not create durable succession.
- Conclusion: The struggle ended institutionally in favour of a stronger sultan, but dynastically remained unresolved, preparing both Balban's centralisation and the Khalji transition.

Why this earns marks: It defines the term cautiously, follows the struggle across four phases, links office and iqta to power, and balances institutional victory with dynastic failure.

Demand decoding: "Examine ... with reference to" requires the Chihalgani to be the running thread of the whole answer, not a side-definition - every phase (formation, succession crisis, Raziya, Balban's rise and reign) must be shown acting through or against that same elite network.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 250 words, use the terminology caution as a short opening move, then run the four-phase chain (formation, 1236-46 crisis, Raziya, Balban naib-to-sultan) as the five evidence units, closing with the "institutional victory, dynastic failure" verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add the specific detail that fewer than twenty-five Chihalgani members are identifiable in surviving lists, since naming that precise qualification (not just "not literally forty") is what separates a source-critical answer from a repeated textbook line.

Mains 15M-3 - Early Sultanate architecture

Question: Early Sultanate architecture was produced through conquest, reuse and technical adaptation rather than a simple story of either destruction or synthesis. Discuss. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The Qutb-Ajmer monuments record coercive appropriation and temple-material reuse, while also documenting Indian craft labour, new congregational forms and gradual mastery of arcuate construction. Both rupture and adaptation must be retained.
- Conquest and reuse: ASI records that Quwwat-ul-Islam's cloisters incorporated members from twenty-seven Hindu and Jaina temples, as stated in its entrance inscription. Adhai Din ka Jhonpra likewise occupies an earlier Sanskrit-college/temple context. This is evidence of conquest and appropriation, not neutral recycling.
- Expediency and claim: Reused pillars supplied material and skilled carving for rapid monumental assertion. Victory inscriptions and congregational plans transformed the political meaning of components; expediency does not erase ideology.
- Craft and form: Indian masons and stone-carvers executed the buildings. Local trabeate/corbelled methods and motifs coexisted with West Asian arch, screen, calligraphy and mosque planning. "Synthesis" is meaningful only when these specific processes are named.
- Technical sequence: Aibak began Qutb Minar and Iltutmish added major storeys. Iltutmish's tomb shows square-to-dome experimentation; Balban's tomb contains the first surviving true arch identified by the assigned source; Alai Darwaza later shows mature technique.
- Limits: Buildings have additions and repair phases; monuments represent elite patronage more than ordinary social experience. "First arch in India" is an overclaim because arches were known earlier.
- Conclusion: Early Sultanate architecture is best read as a conflict-laden laboratory where reused material, local skill and new political-religious forms produced a changing architectural language.

Why this earns marks: It names four monuments, uses ASI inscriptional evidence, distinguishes ideology from expediency and traces technical development with a precise true-arch caveat.

Demand decoding: "Discuss" a stated thesis (conquest, reuse and adaptation, not simple destruction/synthesis) requires the answer to argue for that specific three-part thesis using named monuments, not simply describe the Qutb complex chronologically.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 250 words, use the ASI-cited temple-spolia fact for the conquest/reuse limb, Indian craft labour and corbelled-to-arcuate experimentation for the adaptation limb, and the Balban-tomb true-arch caveat as the technical-sequence closer, ending on the "conflict-laden laboratory" verdict.

How to improve this answer: Name the exact "twenty-seven Hindu and Jaina temples" figure from the ASI-cited inscription rather than a vague "temple material," since a precise, sourced number is what earns marks over a plausible-sounding generalisation.

Mains 20M-1 - Nature of the early Sultanate

Question: Was the early Delhi Sultanate a centralised territorial state or a negotiated network of military power? Analyse. (20 marks, 300 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: It was centralised in sovereign claim, capital institutions and fiscal-military aspiration, but negotiated and uneven in operation. The apparent alternatives describe different levels of the same state.
- Central apex: Aibak's separation from Ghazni and Iltutmish's defeat of Aram, Yildiz and Qubacha established independent sovereignty. The sultan distributed office and iqta, commanded the army, minted currency and claimed royal justice. Delhi's court, chancery and monumental programme made the apex visible.
- Institutional density: Wazir, ariz, insha, qazi-sadr functions, barids, khalisa and iqta differentiated central tasks. Iltutmish's tanka-jital and 1229 investiture strengthened fiscal and symbolic authority. The exact departmental form evolved and cannot be treated as a modern bureaucracy.
- Negotiated implementation: Muqtis, fort commanders, tributary rulers and local khuts, muqaddams, chiefs and accountants translated orders into revenue and force. An iqta was transferable in principle, but distance and

armed followings enabled autonomy.

- Regional evidence: Bengal repeatedly submitted and rebelled; Iltutmish's Gujarat venture failed; Ranthambhor could be held indirectly; western Punjab was exposed to Mongols. Balban killed Tughril but Bughra Khan later detached Bengal.
- Social composition: The ruling elite was initially Turkic-Tajik and Persianate, yet the state relied on Indian Muslim officers, Hindu chiefs, soldiers, artisans and agrarian intermediaries. It was an institutional form of conquest, but not socially self-contained.
- Centralising turn: Balban's court ritual, spies, direct force, road security and iqta supervision increased royal capacity. His dependence on personal coercion, narrow high-born ideology and failed succession reveals the limit.
- Conceptual qualification: It was neither a modern unitary territorial state nor a formless confederacy. "Feudal" and "theocratic" labels require precise definitions.
- Conclusion: The best model is a hierarchical military-fiscal network: dense at Delhi and the upper doab, thinner and more negotiated toward Punjab, Bengal and Rajasthan.

Why this earns marks: It resolves the binary through level-of-analysis, uses institutions plus four regional tests, includes social composition and ends with a spatially graded verdict.

Demand decoding: "Analyse" a stated either/or ("centralised territorial state OR negotiated network") requires the answer to resolve the binary rather than pick one side - the highest-scoring move is showing both descriptions are true at different levels (apex versus operation).

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 300 words, structure by level, not by ruler: apex/sovereign claim, institutional density (wazir/ariz/insha/barid), negotiated implementation (muqtis, local intermediaries), then four regional stress-tests (Bengal, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Punjab) before the "hierarchical military-fiscal network" conclusion.

How to improve this answer: Add one explicit sentence stating why "feudal" and "theocratic" are inadequate labels here - iqta was transferable state revenue, not hereditary property, and caliphal idiom did not equal caliphal administration - since blocking those two mislabels is itself a mark-earning move in this specific question.

Mains 20M-3 - Sources and historiography of the Mamluk century

Question: Evaluate the textual and material sources for the Mamluk period and show how they shape modern interpretations. (20 marks, 300 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The Mamluk century is reconstructed from Persian court texts, advice literature, coins, inscriptions and monuments. Their combined strength is institutional and political detail; their shared weakness is elite selection, uneven chronology and silence on much of society.
- Hasan Nizami: Taj-ul-Ma'asir offers an early Ghurid-Aibak conquest narrative and language of legitimation. Ornate panegyric, selective chronology and court dependence require separation of report from rhetoric.
- Minhaj-us-Siraj: Tabaqat-i Nasiri is indispensable for Ghurid genealogy, Bakhtiyar, Iltutmish, Raziya and the early Balban world. Minhaj's contemporary position improves access, but clerical values, patronage and office interests shape his account; his judgement on Raziya exposes gender bias.
- Fakhr-i Mudabbir: Political-military advice illuminates ideals of army, hierarchy and literate administration. Prescriptive norms cannot prove implementation.
- Barani: Writing decades later, he supplies the Chihalgani label, Balban's ceremonies, noble exclusivity, barids and justice. His high-born prejudice and normative theory make literal numbers, speeches and motives unsafe without corroboration.
- Coins and inscriptions: Aibak-Iltutmish titulature, mints, tanka-jital circulation, caliphal formulas and Qutb inscriptions offer more contemporary public claims. Circulation and titulature do not map uniform power.
- Architecture: Quwwat-ul-Islam, Qutb Minar, Ajmer, Sultan Ghari, Iltutmish's and Balban's tombs reveal patronage, spolia, craft and technical sequence. Repair phases and elite survival complicate reading.
- Silence and social history: Court texts marginalise cultivators, artisans, women outside the palace and regional voices. Local intermediaries and craft agency must be inferred cautiously from institutions and material practice.

- Historiography: Colonial "Slave dynasty/despotism" labels over-literalised status and rupture; institutional studies recovered iqta and state formation; Persianate-network, gender and architectural readings add mobility, source position and material complexity.
- Conclusion: Strong interpretation comes from triangulation: every claim should name evidence, state significance and expose what the archive cannot prove.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates five source classes, names works and monuments, links bias to specific interpretations and ends with a reusable historical method.

Demand decoding: "Evaluate ... and show how they shape modern interpretations" is a two-part demand - assess each source class's strength/limit, and then explicitly connect that limit to a named historiographical shift (colonial, institutional, gender-critical), not just list sources.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In 300 words, take six source classes (Hasan Nizami, Minhaj, Fakhr-i Mudabbir, Barani, coins/inscriptions, architecture) as evidence units, then use one closing paragraph to name the three historiographical schools (colonial "despotism," institutional/material, gender/source-critical) each source class helped produce or correct.

How to improve this answer: Add the specific link that Minhaj's own gendered verdict on Raziya is the same passage gender-critical historians later reread to expose clerical bias, since naming that exact textual link (not just "gender bias exists") is what proves the "shape modern interpretations" half of the demand.